

Global Leave & Time-Off Policy

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What's New in 2025? We have significantly modernized our leave policy to deeply support mental well-being, flexibility, and family planning. Sick leaves have doubled, Mental Wellness days have been introduced as a new category, and Paternity/Secondary Caregiver leave has been massively expanded. We have also shifted to an upfront annual accrual model.

1. Overview and Philosophy

At NovaTech Industries, we believe that bringing your best self to work requires taking time away from work to recharge, rest, and handle personal matters. This policy applies to all global full-time employees. Unlike previous years, all base leave entitlements are credited upfront in full on January 1st of every year, eliminating the quarterly wait.

2. Standard Leave Entitlements (2025 Updated Matrix)

Leave Type	Annual Quota	Carry Forward Limits & Usage Rules
Annual Leave (AL)	20 days	Max 40 days carry forward to the next year. Encashment is allowed at year-end for unused days exceeding the 20-day threshold. Requires 1 week notice for requests longer than 4 days.
Sick & Caregiver Leave (SL)	10 days	Lapses entirely at year-end. Can be used for personal illness, medical appointments, or caring for a sick immediate family member. Medical certificates are only requested for absences exceeding 4 consecutive days.

Mental Wellness Days (MWD)	3 days	Lapses at year-end. No questions asked, auto-approved. Designed to prevent burnout. Cannot be clubbed with Annual Leave to extend a vacation.
Volunteer Time Off (VTO)	2 days	Fully paid time off to volunteer at recognized 501(c)(3) or equivalent non-profit organizations. Proof of volunteering is required post-event.

3. Parental & Life Event Leaves

- **Primary Caregiver (Maternity/Adoption):** 26 weeks of fully paid leave. For adoptions, this applies to children under the age of 5.
- **Secondary Caregiver (Paternity/Partner):** Increased significantly to 4 weeks (up from 3 days in 2023) to be taken flexibly within the first year of birth/adoption.
- **Bereavement Leave:** 5 days for the loss of an immediate family member (spouse, child, parent, sibling), and 2 days for extended family.
- **Domestic Abuse Support Leave:** Up to 10 days of paid leave to seek medical attention, legal assistance, or safe housing.

4. Digital Nomad / Remote Work Policy

In addition to standard leaves, employees are entitled to our "Work From Anywhere" benefit. You can work from a different state or country for up to **30 days per calendar year**. This is not a "leave" but a change of working location. Approval from the functional manager is required 2 weeks in advance to ensure time zone overlap and tax compliance checks.

5. Sabbatical & Career Breaks

Employees with 4+ years of continuous service can apply for an unpaid Career Break of up to 6 months. This can be used for higher education, travel, or personal projects. NovaTech guarantees a return to the same or a strictly equivalent role upon completion of the break.

6. Application Process and Workday Integration

All leaves must be requested and tracked in **Workday**. Approvals for Annual Leaves > 5 days require manager consent in the system. Mental Wellness Days and Sick Leaves <= 2 days are auto-approved by the system upon submission to remove friction. During probation (first 90 days), employees may only access accrued pro-rata leave, not the full annual upfront balance.